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Antisemitism is real. So is the Palestinian struggle

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While my fellow Democrats and I proudly rally in support of LGBTQ+ students and other marginalized communities, I am deeply alarmed to see many of our lawmakers in Sacramento backing legislation that betrays our most fundamental values.

Assembly Bill 715, sponsored by Assemblymember Dawn Addis and cosponsored by Sen. Scott Wiener, Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel, Rick Chavez-Zbur and others, directly threatens democratic discourse, academic freedom and inclusive education in California.

Rushed through the Assembly Education Committee on May 14 with little to no opportunity for public scrutiny, AB 715 is being advanced under the guise of combating antisemitism. But in reality, it is a sweeping and dangerous bill that targets discussions of Palestine and silences Arab-American students, educators and their allies. The bill's language, which remains obscured from public view at this stage, raises red flags about its true intent and impact.

When legislation is crafted and pushed forward without transparency, we must ask: What are its authors trying to hide? At the core of AB 715 is the weaponization of California's Uniform Complaint Procedures, which allow students and families to report incidents of discrimination in schools. Under AB 715, educators and school staff could face punishment simply for discussing the history and current events surrounding Israel and Palestine, particularly when those discussions include critical perspectives on the actions of the Israeli government in Gaza. This bill opens the door for political censorship in our classrooms, where nuance and truth should prevail, not fear.

Even more troubling is the bill's plan to establish a state antisemitism coordinator and institutionalize the controversial International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA) working definition of antisemitism into California policy. The IHRA definition conflates legitimate criticism of Israel with antisemitism, chilling open inquiry, and suppressing the voices of those - particularly Palestinians and their advocates - who speak out against state violence and injustice.

It's essential to recognize that many Jewish organizations, scholars and human rights groups have explicitly rejected the IHRA definition for this very reason. Yet AB 715 would embed it into our education system as a litmus test for permissible speech.

The consequences of this cannot be overstated. In a time when students are increasingly engaged in social justice, global politics and solidarity movements, AB 715 sends a chilling message: Some truths are too dangerous to teach. Some histories are too controversial to acknowledge. Some communities - namely, Palestinian and Arab-American students - are too inconvenient to be heard.

Let me be clear: Antisemitism is real, and it must be confronted wherever it arises. Jewish students and communities deserve to feel safe, respected, and affirmed in our schools and society. But fighting antisemitism should never come at the cost of silencing others.

It should not mean erasing Palestinian narratives or equating criticism of a government with hatred toward an entire people. True solidarity requires us to reject all forms of racism and bigotry, not to pit communities against each other or use policy to shield governments from accountability.

Our classrooms must be spaces where students learn to think critically, engage compassionately and confront the complexities of our world, not spaces where educators are policed and punished for facilitating honest dialogue. If

passed, AB 715 would encourage schools to surveil and silence discussions on Palestine, apartheid, military occupation and the lived experiences of millions of people.

It would make teachers second-guess their curriculum, fearing that even mentioning Gaza or displacement could invite accusations of antisemitism and open them to disciplinary action.

This is especially dangerous given the broader political context. Across the country, we are witnessing an alarming crackdown on dissent, particularly dissent that centers Palestinian rights.

Peaceful student protests are being criminalized. Faculty members are being doxxed or fired. University administrators are yielding to political pressure to shut down pro-Palestinian speech.

Now, with AB 715, California risks joining this wave of repression under the pretense of combating hate. The supporters of AB 715 are organizing swiftly, using political influence and coordinated messaging to push this bill forward.

Those of us who believe in democratic education, freedom of expression and justice for all must respond with equal urgency. Californians from every background must speak out against this bill, not only to defend Palestinian voices but also to defend the principle that no community should be erased from our classrooms.

To lawmakers: If you truly stand for equity, inclusion, and democratic values, you must oppose AB 715. Do not allow fear, political pressure, or misinformation to override your conscience. This bill is not a shield against hate - it is a tool of repression.

To Californians: You must act now. Call your representatives. Testify. Write letters. Protest.

Share this message. Do not allow this bill to become law.

The future of free, honest, and inclusive education in California depends on it.

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